2026 Individual Development Plan

The IDP is a collaborative process to support your growth while advancing CACF's mission. Use this workbook to reflect on the past year, align your vision with our values and competencies, set measurable goals, and turn those goals into an actionable plan with clear accountability.

Before You Begin

This workbook is designed to be completed over time, not in one sitting. Give yourself space to reflect honestly. There are no wrong answers — the goal is self-awareness, alignment, and growth.

Tip: Start with the Lookback. Reflecting on the past year first will ground everything that follows — your performance assessment, your values alignment, and your goals will all be sharper when they're built on honest reflection.

Tip: Be specific. The more concrete your examples and goals, the more useful this document becomes in your conversations with your manager.

Tip: This is a living document. Return to it at your mid-year check-in and year-end review. Update your progress, adjust your goals, and note what's changed.

Employee Name:		**Manager Name:**	
Current Job Title:		**Department:**	
Hire Date:		**Period Covered:**	
IDP Conversation Date:		**Mid-Year Check-In Date:**	
Year-End Review Date:			

How This IDP Workbook Flows

Lookback — Reflect on the Past Year	Assess your experiences, accomplishments, challenges, and lessons learned. This reflection grounds your development in self-awareness and helps clarify what to carry forward, stop, or improve.
Alignment — Job Description Review	Review your job description and reflect on alignment between your day-to-day responsibilities and your official role.
Performance — Assess Current Strengths and Gaps	Evaluate your performance across job-related and personal competencies using the provided performance framework. Your manager will complete a parallel assessment.
Vision, Values, & Strategy — Define Your Direction	Articulate your 1-year and 3-year vision. Reflect on how your work aligns with CACF's values and strategic pillars.
Goals & Development — Translate Vision Into Action	Develop 2–4 clear goals with measurable milestones. Identify the skills, knowledge, experiences, and support you need to grow.
Implementation & Accountability — Operationalize the Plan	Document the specific actions, owners, timelines, and follow-up rhythms needed to achieve your goals.

Section 1: Lookback (Prior Year Reflection)

The Lookback is your opportunity to pause, reflect, and share insights from the past year. It is not about listing everything you did; instead, it's about highlighting the most meaningful experiences, results, and lessons. Use this section to celebrate accomplishments, surface challenges, and offer ideas that can strengthen your role, team, and CACF as a whole.

How to approach this section: Think about the past year as a story with chapters — what were the turning points? Don't just list tasks you completed. Focus on moments that changed something: a relationship that deepened, a skill that clicked, a process that broke, an idea that took hold.

Big Wins

Highlight your proudest accomplishments this year. Think about impact: What did you achieve that made a difference for your team, donors, partners, or community? Include both tangible outcomes (projects completed, goals met, efficiencies created) and intangible outcomes (relationships built, leadership shown, personal growth).

Think about: What would your colleagues, partners, or community members say was your biggest contribution this year? What are you most proud of — and why? Consider impact beyond your immediate team.

✎ **Example:** *Led the transition to our new CRM system, training 12 staff members and reducing data entry time by 40%. This also strengthened our donor reporting — the Philanthropic Engagement team credited the new system with helping them meet Q3 engagement targets.*

What's Working?

Identify the practices, habits, or systems that help you succeed. Consider how these align with CACF's values (Curiosity, Proximity, Truth, Repair, Solidarity) and strategic pillars.

What's Not Working?

Share obstacles or recurring challenges that made your work harder or less effective. Be honest but constructive—framing issues in terms of what's getting in the way of doing your best work.

What Would You Change/Implement?

Suggest improvements, new ideas, or changes to how we work. Be specific—think about systems, tools, practices, or cultural shifts.

Think about: If you had full authority for one day, what would you fix or build? What have you seen work elsewhere that CACF could adopt? Be bold — this is the space for creative problem-solving.

✎ **Example:** *I'd implement a shared project tracker across departments so we can see dependencies and avoid last-minute fire drills. I've seen Asana used effectively at partner organizations and believe it could work here.*

Section 2: Job Description Review

Review your current job description alongside the Performance Framework for your role level. Use this space to reflect on alignment between your day-to-day responsibilities and your official job description.

Why this matters: Job descriptions are snapshots of a role at a moment in time. As CACF evolves, so does your work. This section helps you and your manager get on the same page about what your role actually looks like today — which is the foundation for setting meaningful goals.

> 💡 *Tip: Pull up your actual job description before completing this section. Read it line by line and note what resonates, what's outdated, and what's missing. If you don't have a copy, ask your manager or HR.*

Are there duties you perform regularly that aren't captured in your job description?

Think about: What do you spend time on each week that someone reading your job description wouldn't expect? Are there informal roles you've taken on (e.g., mentoring, troubleshooting, event planning)?

> ✏️ **Example:** *I've become the de facto point person for onboarding new hires in our department, including creating orientation schedules and check-in agendas. This isn't in my job description but takes 3–5 hours per month.*

Are there listed responsibilities that no longer apply or have shifted?

Think about: When you last read your job description, what felt outdated? Has a program been sunset, a tool replaced, or a process changed since you were hired?

> ✏️ **Example:** *My JD lists 'manage the annual gala logistics' but that responsibility moved to the Events team 18 months ago. I still support day-of coordination but no longer own the project.*

Are there areas where your role has grown beyond the original scope?

Think about: Are you operating at a level above your title? Are you leading things you weren't hired to lead? This is important context for your goals and any future title or compensation conversations.

> ✏️ **Example:** *I was hired as a Program Coordinator but now lead stakeholder engagement for two major initiatives and regularly present to the board committee — responsibilities more aligned with a Manager-level role.*

This reflection helps ensure your development goals are grounded in an accurate picture of your role and supports productive conversations with your manager about expectations, growth, and clarity.

Section 3: Performance Framework

This framework outlines the knowledge, delivery/execution, and communication & leadership competencies expected at each role level at CACF. Use it as a shared reference for self-assessment and manager assessment.

How to Use: As you review the descriptors, use the following color-coding to highlight the cells that apply to you. This creates a visual map of where you are, what your role requires, and where you want to grow.

GREEN = Current Skills	YELLOW = Required for Role	BLUE = Target / Aspirational

How to approach this section: The Performance Framework is not a report card. It's a shared language for talking about what's expected at each level and where you are in your development. Use it to have an honest conversation with your manager — not to prove you're perfect, but to surface where investment in your growth will have the most impact.

Tip: Start with your current role column. Read each descriptor and ask yourself: 'Can I point to a specific example of this from the past year?' If yes, highlight it green. If it's expected at your level but you're still building the skill, highlight it yellow. If it describes where you want to be next, highlight it blue.

Tip: Look one level up. Reviewing the competencies at the next role level helps you identify stretch goals and signals to your manager that you're thinking about growth beyond your current position.

Role Levels

Role Level	Description
Coordinator	Supporting-level player developing their skills and working to understand organizational context.
Manager	Established performer with strong communication skills who proactively builds relationships.
Senior Manager	High-level performer with strong relationships and ability to lead projects.
Director	Leading performer with ability to manage projects and people; pushes convention and drives change.
C-Suite	Effective leader focused on building teams and process for high impact results; significant management experience.
President & CEO	Dynamic leader focused on strategic vision, growing talent, and execution; managing managers and multiple teams.

Performance Framework

Title:	Coordinator	Manager	Senior Manager	Director	C-Suite	President & CEO
Description	*Supporting-level player developing their skills and working to understand organizational context.*	*Established performer with strong communication skills who proactively builds relationships.*	*High-level performer with strong relationships and ability to lead projects.*	*Leading performer with ability to manage projects and people; pushes convention and drives change.*	*Effective leader focused on building teams and process for high impact results; significant management experience; recruits and hires teams.*	*Dynamic leader focused on strategic vision, growing talent, and execution; significant management experience managing managers and multiple teams.*
Knowledge: This category focuses on breadth and depth of knowledge; how their area(s) of expertise develop over time.	Broad, generalist knowledge of core elements or concepts within their role.	Focus on attaining expertise in one or more areas of their role.	Expertise in one or more areas of their role.	Go-to expert for functional knowledge/guidance; anticipates issues and makes thoughtful, strategic decisions to address them.	Anticipates broad change pertaining to their areas of expertise and ensures CACF stays ahead of the curve.	Deep and thorough understanding of all CACF functions and roles.
	Focus on learning existing tools, resources, processes, and stakeholders.	Rarely makes same mistake twice; learns and applies lessons from failure.	Understands and makes well-reasoned decisions and tradeoffs within their area(s) of expertise.	Owner, and expert in large parts, of their job function.	Understands deeply the end-to- end nature of their job functions and is able to clearly articulate limits while proposing solutions.	Clear and consistently demonstrated expertise as an operator, manager, and leader within the context of CACF and the broader nonprofit sector.
	Learns quickly and makes steady progress with frequent significant feedback from more senior team members.	Learns quickly and makes steady progress without the need for frequent significant feedback from more senior team members.	Demonstrates knowledge of sector trends and regularly seeks external expertise to accelerate their learning.	Developing proven structure and processes that helps team achieve outstanding results.	Uses their expertise to develop ideas that enable many potential futures without knowing exactly what the future is.	Understands CACF's strategic connection and interplay with the nonprofit sector and the community at-large.
		Begins to build understanding of broader organizational context and goals.	Clarifies success metrics and ties efforts toward delivering mission value.	Researches and proposes new tools to facilitate self-, team- and CACF-wide learnings.	Solid understanding of people management strategies and how to develop leaders in that function to be successful.	Demonstrated expertise in Board operations.
	Understands CACF's equity statement and CACF's vision for and commitment to a region where all community members have the opportunity to thrive, supported by a nonprofit sector that celebrates diversity, values inclusion, and centers equity work across all aspects of our work.		An understanding of impact and success helps to focus their efforts, as well as those of their function/team.	Track record of creating improvements across major areas of their function(s), bringing about positive change.	Holistic, integrated understanding of organizational context.	Demonstrated expertise in philanthropy and philanthropic relationship- building.
	Displays clear willingness and commitment to ongoing learning about issues, ideas, concepts, and history related to systems and policies of exclusion, oppression, and racism that created inequities and to skills and practices of diversity, equity, and inclusion that will dismantle them.		Deepening understanding of broader organizational context and goals.	Understanding of people management practices and effective at implementation.		Demonstrated expertise in people management strategies and how to develop leaders to be successful.
	Understands and values racial equity as an organizational operating principle and an integral part of CACF's approach inside and outside the organization, and is able to communicate why racial equity aligns with CACF's mission.			Holistic, integrated understanding of organizational context.	Demonstrates an understanding of the impact of structural racism and inequity and a commitment to fostering more inclusive organizations and advocating for equitable policies and practices that support all community members to thrive.	
	Understands the history of racial inequality in America, the idea of race as a social construct, the manifestations of personal, institutional and systemic racism, and the role of the invention of "race" in systemically isolating, separating, and disempowering groups of people.		Seeks out and supports opportunities for engagement in diversity, equity and inclusion efforts.			
			Intentionally surfaces internal and community inequities and data disparities and connects diversity, equity and inclusion to the work and mission of CACF.			

Title:	Coordinator	Manager	Senior Manager	Director	C-Suite	President & CEO
Delivery/Execution: This category focuses on what they're expected to deliver on and how they go about doing that.	Develops their productivity skills by learning and refining their working style and time management.	Makes steady progress on tasks/projects; knows when to ask for help in order to get unblocked.	Persistent in the face of roadblocks; handling them efficiently, pulling in others as necessary.	Able to scope work or projects into well-defined milestones and timeframes.	Consistently delivers large projects involving one or more teams' contributions, on time and at a high level of quality.	Develops and deploys new strategies for building a high- performance organization in line with emerging needs and opportunities.
	Capable of taking well-defined tasks/projects and completing them.	Able to own small to medium tasks/projects from planning through completion.	Requires minimal direction/oversight.	Identifies and proactively tackles future issues before they grow into something even bigger.	Quickly breaks down complex problems into potential solutions, knowns and unknowns, in order to get to solid resolutions faster.	Ensures organization-wide understanding of strategies.
	Deomonstrates customer service focus by responding timely and thoroughly to team members, member organizations, partners, and the public.	Capable of prioritizing and managing multiple tasks/projects simultaneously; avoids getting caught up in unimportant details.	Takes initiative to fix issues before being assigned.	Recognized as prolific contributor, regularly delivering projects or work; manages expectations and articulates reasons when not possible.	Solves toughest problems the team encounters.	Drives impact and improvements.
	Develops an understanding of the role that diversity, equity, and inclusion play in a healthy nonprofit and in a healthy community.	Capable of providing support for their function, including parts they are not yet familiar with.	Delivers well-researched solutions.	Proactive in identifying and clearing roadblocks.	Builds, supports, and coaches high-functioning, motivated teams.	Strategically plans for scale.
		Proactively builds relationships and delivers exceptional customer service, internally and externally.	Develops and implements strategies for their area of function(s).	Excels at prioritizing highest-impact projects.	Drives organizational culture/work/values.	Develops/operationalizes strategies that advance org growth.
		Applies a diveristy, equity, and inclusion lens to inform discussions and decisions.	End-to-end responsibility on increasingly complex projects.	Connects team's efforts with grasp of ecosystem and organizational context.	Leads/supports functions while achieving impact across all areas.	Owns organization budget.
			Develops ability to work across teams, identifying and incorporating knowledge, skills, and resources.	Oversees delivery of multiple projects/initiatives on clear timelines.	Active in budget planning; owns function budgets.	Proven board leadership: cultivates, partners with, and engages board to achieve strategic goals.
			Takes ownership of their development.	Creates multi-function team approaches; maximizes partnerships/resources.	Identifies/maximizes external opportunities; strategically develops new business.	
			Proactively builds strong relationships; anticipates needs; responsible for exceptional delivery and service.	Leads hiring efforts; builds strong relationships of increasing complexity.	Cultivates strong, transparent relationships with team, board, and partners; models exceptional service.	
			Upholds racial equity outcomes, goals and performance measures with team and on projects.		Commitment to building an anti-racist organization and to understanding and countering all systems of oppression within the sector.	
			Incorporates diversity, equity and inclusion ideas, concepts, and history into project work and methodology.		Sets racial equity outcomes, goals, and performance measures at organizational level.	
					Incorporates diversity, equity, and inclusion ideas, concepts, and history into organizational philosophy, strategy, and execution.	

Title:	Coordinator	Manager	Senior Manager	Director	C-Suite	President & CEO
Communication & Leadership: This category focuses on how they communicate and lead people and/or projects.	Effective in communicating progress to the team.	Gives timely, helpful feedback to peers and managers.	Always communicates decisions at the right time, to the right people, and in the right format.	Listens and guides debate to help reach consensus and, once decisions are made, clearly communicates and backs that decision.	Acts as multiplier by creating systems, processes, or policies that raise the level of productivity of the entire organization.	Makes real change in how CACF approaches its business to maintain relevance and promote culture.
	Eager to find ways to improve; asks for and implements feedback/clarification into their work to reduce mistakes and accelerate growth specific to their role and as a member of the team.	Communicates assumptions and gets clarification on tasks up front to minimize the need for rework.	Shares and applies learnings and best practices.	Is able to facilitate cross-team work, improving the effectiveness of others.	Communicates the value of CACF and promotes CACF as community asset and leading resource via talks, presentations, posts.	Confidently articulates vision that excites and inspires staff, members, and partners.
		Understands how their work fits into the larger organization and identifies areas of concern and opportunity.	Communicates and partners effectively across functions; is able to work well with whatever function necessary.	Sets short-medium term strategic direction, by looking ahead 6–12 months.	Leads conversations internally about direction of major areas, drives team-wide consensus into adoption, and uses it to inspire other team members.	Proven leadership, coaching, and relationship management experience.
			Proactively identifies areas of opportunity and concern for their own work and adjacent work; communicates these early to help course-correct.	Identifies areas of greatest need and creates plan to improve.	Seen as role model and mentor.	A persuasive and passionate communicator with excellent interpersonal, presentation, and multidisciplinary project management skills, and the experience and energy to be an engaged and effective spokesperson, relationship builder and fundraiser.
			Regularly communicates goals and progress.	Positively impacts CACF's growth.		
				Creates opportunities for people to grow and flourish.		
				Manages independently – communicates context to the team and surfaces needs to relevant senior staff.		
				Sets clear expectations for team members – solicits, synthesizes, and delivers feedback.		
				Comfortable managing team members with different skill sets and areas of focus.		
				Recognized for impact on team culture – people are excited to work with them.		
	Engages with curiosity, humility, and openness in discussions about race, diversity, equity, inclusion, oppression and power inside and outside CACF.		Reflects on and communicates clearly and comfortably about what diversity, equity, and inclusion means at CACF and in the world, including communicating about identified inequities and required changes.		Leads with vulnerability and openness; initiates and facilitates conversations within CACF and with external stakeholders to deepen mutual understanding and learning about race, diversity, equity, inclusion, oppression and power.	
	Understands how the construct of race has impacted the distribution of power and the recognition of innovation, creativity, and voice throughout history; looks critically at existing power structures and is mindful of power dynamics in inter-personal and professional situations.		Critically examines community data, social issues, and messages for biases and inequalities and their impact on oneself and others' thinking, emotions, and behaviors; proposes alternatives to reduce and eliminate biases and inequities.		Intentionally creates the space and opportunities for shared power and authority within CACF.	
			Manages own power and decision-making with accountability, transparency, inclusion, humility, and awareness.		Creates and promotes a positive, inclusive climate that attracts and motivates a diverse staff, board, and membership.	
					Leverages own position and authority to lead CACF in consciously equitable and inclusive decisions.	

Adapted from the CNE Performance Framework.

Self-Assessment

Review the competency descriptors for your current role level. For each category, reflect on where you feel confident, where you're growing, and where you see gaps. Be specific—ground your assessment in examples from the past year.

How to approach your self-assessment: This isn't about being modest or inflating your performance. It's about building self-awareness. The most useful self-assessments are honest, specific, and forward-looking. Your manager will complete a parallel review — where your assessments align builds confidence; where they diverge opens valuable conversation.

Think about: For each category, ask yourself: "Can I point to a specific moment or project from this year that demonstrates this?" If the answer is yes, that's a strength. If you hesitate, that's a growth area worth naming.

💡 *Tip: Don't try to fill every cell with a novel. A few strong, honest sentences per category are more valuable than paragraphs of vague self-praise. Focus on patterns, not one-off moments.*

✎ **Example:** *Knowledge — Strengths: "I've developed strong expertise in grant compliance this year. I can now independently navigate federal reporting requirements and have trained two colleagues on the process." Growth: "I need to build a better understanding of our investment portfolio. I avoid conversations about it because I feel underqualified."*

✎ **Example:** *Communication & Leadership — Strengths: "I consistently communicate project updates to stakeholders on time, and my director has noted improvement in how I frame recommendations." Growth: "I struggle to give direct feedback to peers. I tend to avoid conflict, which sometimes lets small issues grow."*

Knowledge

Strengths / Where I'm Confident	Areas for Growth / Gaps

Delivery/Execution

Strengths / Where I'm Confident	Areas for Growth / Gaps

Communication & Leadership

Strengths / Where I'm Confident	Areas for Growth / Gaps

Manager Assessment

Your manager will complete this parallel review using the same framework. This is not a scoring exercise; it's meant to surface where perceptions align and where they differ, so your IDP conversation can focus on the areas that matter most.

Tip for Managers: Ground your observations in specific examples. Instead of "needs to improve communication," try "I've noticed updates on the XYZ project sometimes come after decisions have already been made — earlier communication would help the team plan better." Specificity makes the feedback actionable.

Tip for Managers: Note where your assessment differs from the employee's self-assessment. These gaps are the most valuable part of the IDP conversation — they reveal blind spots (in both directions) and create opportunities for honest dialogue.

Knowledge

Observed Strengths	Areas for Development

Delivery/Execution

Observed Strengths	Areas for Development

Communication & Leadership

Observed Strengths	Areas for Development

Section 4: Values & Capability Alignment

Connect your performance and work with CACF's values and capabilities. Respond to each value and capability individually to make your reflection concrete and actionable.

How to approach this section: This section asks you to move beyond "I believe in these values" to "here's how I lived them this year." Values alignment isn't about perfection — it's about awareness. Where you fell short is just as important to name as where you showed up well.

Tip: Use the three-column format (Reflection / Evidence / Next Steps) as a progression: What do I think? → What actually happened? → What will I do about it? This structure turns abstract values into concrete commitments.

Tip: Be honest about misalignment. If a value feels aspirational rather than practiced, say so. Naming the gap is the first step toward closing it — and your manager will appreciate the candor.



Values Alignment

For each value, reflect on how it showed up (or didn't) in your work this year. Use the three columns to move from reflection to evidence to action.

✎ **Example:** *Proximity — Reflection: 'I realize most of my community partner interactions this year were by email or phone. I haven't been as physically present as I'd like.' Examples/Evidence: 'Attended 2 community events (down from 5 last year). Relied on secondhand reports for the rural communities initiative.' Next Steps: 'Commit to one in-person community visit per month in Q1–Q2. Shadow a Community Engagement colleague on a partner site visit by March.'*

Curiosity	We are committed to listening and learning with an openness that invites deeper exploration. We do not have all the answers and we value a growth mindset.	
Reflection	**Examples / Evidence**	**Next Steps**

Proximity	Our community work benefits from getting close and being authentically connected with those who have direct and lived experience with the community trends we seek to change.	
Reflection	**Examples / Evidence**	**Next Steps**

Truth	We are committed to truth-telling about our collective past and our shared fates. We believe honest hindsight about where we've been is necessary to help us understand our present and to create a better future.	
Reflection	**Examples / Evidence**	**Next Steps**
Repair	We seek opportunities to help our communities heal from past harm and to set course for a renewed and regenerative future state.	
Reflection	**Examples / Evidence**	**Next Steps**

Solidarity	We intentionally align and partner with those who have been excluded from the full benefits of our region in order to create a more equitable and inclusive place for all.	
Reflection	**Examples / Evidence**	**Next Steps**

Capabilities

These six capabilities describe the personal capacities we need to do equity-centered work. They are developmental — you're not expected to have arrived, but you are expected to be on the journey.

Think about: Which of these capabilities feels most natural to you right now? Which one makes you uncomfortable, and what might that discomfort be telling you? Where has a colleague modeled one of these competencies in a way that taught you something?

✎ **Example:** *Direct Communication — Reflection: 'I tend to soften critical feedback to avoid conflict, which sometimes means the message doesn't land.' What will you do next year?: 'Practice giving feedback using the SBI model (Situation-Behavior-Impact) in at least two conversations per quarter.' Support needed: 'Would benefit from a feedback skills workshop or coaching from my manager on how to have direct conversations with care.'*

Reflect on each capability and plan your development:

Growth mindset	Be willing and able to grow and change and do things differently. Go beyond what training, experience, or upbringing has taught us. Be humble, curious, and open-minded.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

Innovation orientation / sense of possibility	Bring a "how can we" or "how could this be possible" mindset. Question the way things have always been done in service of making change and progress.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

Authenticity & vulnerability	Be able to bring yourself and share yourself with the team. Be genuine and true to ourselves with each other. This is crucial to building trust.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

A spirit of solidarity & differentiation	Recognize and value our shared fate and invest in each other's success. Appreciate each person's uniqueness and do not equate experiences or assume similar identities make us the same.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

Direct communication	Speak our own truth and listen deeply. Give and receive feedback thoughtfully and respectfully, recognizing this is critical for growth and accountability.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

Responsibility for learning	Do the personal work to dismantle internalized ideas about self and others, to see the larger system and our individual locations in it, and work together as effective change agents.	
Reflection	**What will you do next year?**	**Support needed**

Section 5: Vision, Goals, & Development

Translate your vision into clear, measurable steps for the year ahead. Set 2–4 goals with milestones, and outline the development activities and resources that will help you achieve them.

How to approach this section: Start with the big picture before you get tactical. Your vision statements should capture what meaningful growth looks like for you — not just a list of tasks or training. Think about who you want to become as a professional, not just what you want to do.

> 💡 *Tip: Dream first, edit later. Write your vision without filtering for realism. Then work backward to identify which parts are achievable this year and which are 3-year aspirations. Your unfiltered vision often reveals what matters most to you.*

1-Year Vision: What do you want to achieve in the next 12 months? What new skills, knowledge, or responsibilities do you want to build? How will you measure success?

Think about: If you could fast-forward to December 2026 and look back on a great year, what would you have accomplished? What skills would you have built? How would your colleagues describe your growth?

> ✏️ **Example:** *By the end of 2026, I want to have led at least one cross-departmental initiative from conception to completion, built stronger data analysis skills through formal training, and deepened my relationships with three community partners in our rural service area. I'll measure success by whether I've delivered a project I can point to with pride and whether my manager sees growth in my strategic thinking.*

3-Year Vision: Where do you see yourself in three years? How might your role evolve? What impact do you hope your work will have?

Think about: Where do you see your career heading? What kind of work energizes you? What would it take to get to the next level — and do you want to?

> ✏️ **Example:** *In three years, I see myself in a Senior Manager or Director role where I'm designing programs, not just executing them. I want to be known for bringing an equity lens to program design and for mentoring newer team members. I'd like to have presented at a regional conference and built a professional network beyond CACF.*

Strategic Pillars

Tip: Use the strategic pillars as an anchor. When writing your goals, ask: 'Which pillar does this goal serve?' This isn't about forcing a connection — it's about ensuring your individual growth contributes to CACF's strategic direction. If a goal doesn't connect to a pillar, that's worth discussing with your manager.

The 4 Pillars of Our Strategy

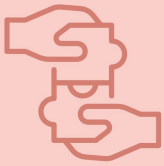
We strive to have a lasting and transformative impact on our region, and we are committed to aligning and focusing resources to maximize that impact. In our strategy, **transformative and lasting change** is accomplished by focusing on the following areas:

Deep & Authentic Relationships



Deep and authentic relationships among the foundation and local residents that ensure more diverse and representative team, board and volunteer composition across the organization, intentional and meaningful relationship-building across our entire service area, customized donor engagement, and strategic stakeholder convenings that build connection and trust.

Catalytic Resources



Catalytic resources that leverage the foundation's strengths and unique tools to increase partnerships between advised and discretionary funding, deliver robust capacity building programming accessible to community-based organizations of various types, provide targeted resources for Black and brown communities, and advance local impact investing.

Influential Leadership

Influential leadership that positions the foundation as a community leader through strategic use of our institutional voice on issues of import to our local region, strategic and engaging donor education that mobilizes philanthropic partnerships, values aligned investing approaches that achieve financial and social return, and promotion of regional data with an equity lens.



Strong Enterprise

Strong enterprise that enables the foundation to have the capacity, skills, knowledge, infrastructure, and culture to deliver on our goals, including user-friendly systems, an anti-racist culture, technical expertise, and strong board and team partnership.



2024-2028 Strategic Direction

How to Write Strong Goals

Your goals are the engine of this workbook. Everything you've reflected on — your lookback, your performance assessment, your values alignment, and your vision — should feed into 2–4 clear, actionable goals. This section walks you through how to write goals that are specific enough to act on, measurable enough to track, and meaningful enough to sustain your motivation.

Element	What It Means for Your IDP
Specific	Name the exact outcome, not a vague aspiration. 'Improve data skills' is too broad. 'Complete the Data Analysis for Nonprofits course and independently produce quarterly program dashboards' is specific.
Measurable	How will you and your manager know you've achieved it? Include numbers, deliverables, or observable changes. 'Led 3 community partner site visits' is measurable; 'got more connected with partners' is not.
Aligned	Every goal should connect to at least one CACF value or strategic pillar. This isn't about forcing a connection — it's about making sure your growth serves both you and the organization.
Realistic	Ambitious is good; impossible is not. You have limited hours, energy, and organizational support. Two or three goals done well beat five goals done halfway.
Time-bound	Break each goal into milestones. Milestones should be checkable: things you can point to and say 'done' or 'not done.'

Understanding the Goals Table — Column by Column

Column	How to Fill It In
Strategic Alignment	Which CACF value and/or strategic pillar does this goal serve? This grounds your personal growth in the organization's direction.
Goal (1-Year)	A clear statement of what you will accomplish by year-end. Start with a verb: 'Lead,' 'Develop,' 'Build,' 'Launch.'
Milestones	Break the goal into manageable checkpoints. Each milestone should be a concrete deliverable or observable outcome, not an activity.
Resources Needed	What do you need to succeed? Budget, tools, access, time, or information. Be specific — this helps your manager advocate for you.
Development Activity	What will you do to build the skills or knowledge needed? Training, mentoring, shadowing, reading, peer learning, conferences.
Timeline / Due Date	When will each milestone be complete? Use quarters (Q1, Q2) or specific months.
Follow-up Method	How will you and your manager check progress? Weekly 1:1s, monthly reviews, quarterly check-ins. Name the cadence.
Sign-off / Notes	Space for manager approval, mid-year notes, or year-end reflections on progress.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

✗ Too many goals	Too many goals dilute your focus and make it hard to make meaningful progress on any of them. Prioritize ruthlessly.
✗ Activity-based milestones	'Attend a training' is an activity, not a milestone. 'Apply training concepts to produce a revised partner survey by Q2' is a milestone — it shows what the activity produced.
✗ Vague language	'Improve communication' could mean almost anything. What kind of communication? With whom? How will you know it improved? Push for precision.
✗ No strategic connection	If a goal doesn't connect to a value or pillar, ask why it's on your IDP. Personal growth goals are valid, but they should still serve the work.
✗ Missing resources	If you don't name what you need, your manager can't help you get it. Budget, time, tools, mentorship — be explicit.

Example: A Well-Written Goal

Below is a sample goal for a Program Administrator at the Coordinator level. Notice how it connects personal growth to organizational strategy, breaks down into quarterly milestones, and names specific resources and development activities.

Strategic Alignment	Catalytic Resources / Proximity
Goal (1-Year)	Lead the Community Partner Roundtable expansion from quarterly to bi-monthly, adding rural partners to deepen CACF's community reach.
Milestones	Q1: Identify 4 new rural community partners and conduct introductory site visits. Q2: Host first expanded bi-monthly Roundtable with new partners included. Q3: Collect structured partner feedback on Roundtable value and format. Q4: Present Roundtable outcomes and expansion recommendations to senior leadership.
Resources Needed	Travel budget for rural site visits ($600); updated partner contact list from Advancement team; meeting space for expanded group.
Development Activity	Complete community engagement training (online, Q1). Shadow a Director-level partner meeting to observe relationship-building at a strategic level (Q2).
Timeline	Q1–Q4 2026 (milestones mapped to each quarter)
Follow-up Method	Monthly check-in with manager; brief written update at each Roundtable.

💡 *Tip: Use this example as a model, not a template. Your goals should reflect your unique role, growth areas, and aspirations. The key elements to replicate are: a clear connection to strategy, milestones you can check off, and named resources so your manager can support you.*

1-Year Goals (with milestones) and Development Planning

Each goal should be specific, measurable, and tied to a timeline. Aim for 2–4 goals. More than four dilutes your focus. Make milestones checkable: 'Improve my writing' isn't a milestone. 'Complete the grant writing workshop by March and draft two grant proposals independently by June' is.

Strategic Alignment (Value/Pillar)	Goal (1-Year)	Milestones	Resources Needed	Development Activity	Timeline / Due Date	Follow-up Method	Sign-off / Notes
Catalytic Resources / Proximity	*Lead the Community Partner Roundtable expansion from quarterly to bi-monthly, adding rural partners.*	*Q1: Identify 4 new rural partners* *Q2: Host first expanded Roundtable* *Q3: Collect partner feedback* *Q4: Present outcomes to leadership*	*Travel budget ($600); partner contacts from PE*	*Community engagement training (Q1); shadow Director-level partner meeting (Q2)*	*Q1–Q4 2026*	*Monthly check-in with manager*	